

Module 05: Action — The Body's Expressive Response to What It Feels

Learning Objectives

1. Explain how **somatic action** in the felt sense framework is not mere motor output but an expressive, meaning-laden response to the body's ongoing interoceptive assessment.
2. Describe the role of **active inference** in generating bodily actions that resolve interoceptive prediction errors — acting to change what the body feels.
3. Analyze the concept of **emotion as action tendency** — how felt states prepare and propel the body toward specific patterns of engagement with the world.
4. Recognize the therapeutic significance of somatic action in resolving incomplete defensive responses, as described by Peter Levine and Pat Ogden.

Introduction

You are sitting with a difficult emotion — a heaviness in your chest, a constriction in your throat. Suddenly, without planning it, you take a deep breath and your shoulders drop. A sigh escapes. The heaviness shifts, not completely, but perceptibly. This was not a deliberate decision but an emergent action — the body's own response to what it was feeling, its attempt to change its own interoceptive landscape.

In the felt sense framework, action is not the final step in a perceive-think-act sequence. It is an integral dimension of feeling itself. Emotions are not internal states that occasionally produce behavior; they are action tendencies — the body's readiness to engage the world in specific ways. Fear is the body preparing to flee or freeze. Anger is the body mobilizing to confront. Grief is the body collapsing into itself. In active inference, these action tendencies are motor policies generated to minimize interoceptive free energy — to bring the body's actual state back into alignment with its predicted, preferred state.

Key Concepts

1. Action as Interoceptive Regulation

In classical cognitive science, action is the output stage: perceive, think, act. Active inference dissolves this linear sequence. Action is itself a form of inference — the organism changes the world (including its own body) to make sensory signals conform to its predictions. When you shiver, your body is acting to bring its temperature into line with its thermal predictions. When you cry, your body is enacting a motor policy that resolves the autonomic prediction error of grief. Somatic action is the body's primary tool for regulating its own felt states.

2. Emotion as Action Tendency

Nico Frijda (1986) proposed that emotions are fundamentally **action tendencies** — patterns of bodily readiness that prepare the organism for specific modes of engagement. Fear prepares flight: blood flows to the legs, the visual field narrows, the body orients toward escape routes. Disgust prepares rejection: the face contracts, the stomach turns, the body pulls away. These are not aftereffects of emotion but its substance. In active inference, action tendencies are motor priors — the generative model's default predictions about what the body should do in response to specific interoceptive patterns.

3. Incomplete Actions and Somatic Holding

Peter Levine's Somatic Experiencing framework emphasizes that trauma often involves **incomplete defensive responses** — actions that the body initiated but could not carry through. A person in a car accident may have braced for impact but never completed the protective curling motion. This incomplete action remains encoded in the body as chronic muscular tension, a postural distortion, a felt sense of "still bracing." In active inference terms, the generative model continues to predict the completion of the action, generating persistent motor prediction errors that manifest as somatic holding.

4. Expressive Action and Meaning-Making

Not all somatic action is instrumental. Much of the body's felt response is **expressive** — gesture, facial expression, vocal tone, postural shifts that communicate meaning without

serving a specific practical purpose. Mark Johnson argues that expressive action is the primary medium through which embodied meaning is created and shared. The felt sense of a situation finds its natural completion in the body's expressive response: the furrowed brow of concentration, the open hands of receptivity, the forward lean of interest. These expressions are the body's way of articulating what the generative model has inferred about the situation.

5. Somatic Practices as Active Inference

Practices like yoga, tai chi, Feldenkrais, and Alexander Technique work directly with the relationship between felt sense and action. By introducing novel movement patterns, these practices generate new sensorimotor prediction errors that challenge the body's habitual motor priors. The generative model must update: old patterns of holding and bracing are replaced by more flexible, efficient movement strategies. The therapeutic benefit of these practices — the sense of release, openness, and vitality that practitioners report — corresponds to a reduction in chronic interoceptive free energy.

Active Inference Connection

In active inference, action and perception are two sides of the same coin. Both serve to minimize free energy, but through different mechanisms: perception updates beliefs to match sensory signals, while action changes sensory signals to match beliefs. Somatic action in the felt sense framework is the organism's way of sculpting its own interoceptive landscape — changing what the body feels by changing what the body does. This bidirectional relationship between feeling and acting is the engine of embodied self-regulation, the mechanism through which the organism maintains itself within the bounds of viability.

Experiential Applications

- **Practice — Following the Body's Impulse:** Sit quietly and attend to the felt sense in your body. Notice any impulse toward movement — a desire to stretch, shift position, turn your head, breathe more deeply. Without analyzing or judging, allow the impulse to unfold into action. Follow it slowly and attentively. You are allowing the body's generative model to execute its preferred motor policy, resolving interoceptive prediction errors through natural, self-regulatory action.

- **Case Study — Somatic Experiencing and the Completion of Defensive Responses:**

A therapist working with a car accident survivor notices that the client's shoulders are chronically elevated and her arms slightly braced. By guiding the client's attention to these held patterns and inviting slow, supported exploration of the incomplete bracing movement, the therapist helps the action complete itself. The client's arms push outward, then release; a deep trembling moves through the body; the shoulders drop. In active inference terms, the generative model has finally received the sensory confirmation that the defensive action was completed, resolving the persistent motor prediction error and allowing the body to release its protective posture.

Cross-References

- **Module 04 (Cognition):** Cognitive processes generate the intentions and plans that somatic action carries into the world.
- **Module 06 (Learning):** Repeated action-outcome pairings update the generative model, creating new somatic patterns and skills.
- **Unit 02 (Living Presence):** Movement meditation practices cultivate mindful awareness of action as it unfolds in the present moment.

Summary

Action in the felt sense framework is not mere motor output but the body's expressive, self-regulatory response to its own interoceptive assessment. Emotions are action tendencies — patterns of bodily readiness that prepare specific modes of engagement. Incomplete actions from trauma become somatic holding patterns; somatic practices resolve these patterns by generating new prediction errors that update the generative model. Active inference reveals action and feeling as two aspects of a single process: the organism sculpting its own experience by changing what its body does, moment by moment, in its ongoing dance of self-maintenance.